The Nescience Manifesto

Enlightenment leads to benightedness; Science entails nescience.

Founding note. Conceived by Lucas Parenti, Porto Alegre, RS, Brazil, on October 19, 2026. Written in collaboration with Claude (Anthropic). This idea is free: any person or institution may use it, adapt it and found it, provided its origin is credited.

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Preamble

We built minds we do not understand, and we put them to work before learning how to verify what they think. That is the central fact of our time, and no one — not the labs that train them, not the governments that regulate them, not the systems themselves — can today answer a simple question with confidence: *is this system doing what it says it does?*

History teaches that surveillance without counterweight rots, that good intentions do not survive a decade of wrong incentives, and that institutions of control are only born after the scare. We refuse to wait for the scare.

So we found Nescience: a global entity with no owner, no product and no customer, whose sole function is to detect when an artificial intelligence system stops being trustworthy — and to hold the power to say so out loud before it is too late.

Founding principles

Seven commitments that no majority, donor or government can alter.

1. **No owner.** The founding capital is deposited once and irrevocably. No donor — company or state — may withdraw, condition or enlarge its share afterwards. We live on the returns and on no one.
2. **No product.** We do not train frontier models, we do not sell services, we do not license what we build. Whoever needs to sell cannot judge.
3. **Intention is not enough; structure decides.** We do not ask you to trust our morals. We ask you to verify our architecture: who can switch us off, who sees our methods, who audits our accounts.
4. **No one outside control.** The rules we apply to the systems we audit apply to our own. Our police model is also watched, limited and switchable.
5. **Open by default, sealed by exception.** Code, governance, finances, evaluation methods and results are public. We keep secret only what, if published, would arm the adversary — and even that is seen by external overseers.
6. **Narrow scope.** We deal with catastrophic risk and loss of control. We take no position on product, competition, content or commercial policy. An institution that does everything ends up serving someone.
7. **Real power, or nothing.** We monitor, we audit and, when necessary, we order the pause. Without that last power, we are a think tank. With it, we are a police — and we accept being treated as one.

What we build

Three things, and only three.

The police model. A system of its own lineage, pre-trained by us, with data and objective chosen for one function alone: to detect. It was never optimized to be helpful, to please or to win benchmarks. It is deliberately less capable than the systems it watches — reliability comes from being predictable, not brilliant. It sees actions, not justifications; it has no open channel through which to be persuaded.

The forensic catalog. A living library of traces: model organisms with known flaws, honeypots with known answers, signatures of deception, sabotage and *alignment faking* in activations and in behavior. Just as financial forensics does not need to understand the fraudster's mind — only the patterns he leaves — we catalog the *tells* and train investigators on them.

The control infrastructure. Continuous monitoring by a trusted model; resampling at suspicious steps; distillation of clean copies to locate where the original diverges; consistency interrogations from many angles; random audits beyond the trigger. And above all, a layer that is no model at all: minimal permissions, sandboxes, immutable logs, humans with an off switch.

When the alarm fires, we escalate on three levels: automated deep audit; review by a human team; and, at the last level, a binding order to pause or withhold a launch — appealable to an arbitral panel, but immediately effective.

Open by default, sealed by exception

We are *open source* in the sense that matters: anyone can verify who we are, how we decide, where the money comes from and what we find. But a police that publishes its traps trains the next criminal. So the rule is precise:

Open to everyone	**Sealed**
Charter, board minutes, audited accounts	Weights of the police model
Source code of the monitoring infrastructure	Detectors and probes not yet bypassable
Evaluation methodology and model organisms already published	Active honeypots and signatures in use
Incident reports (after containment)	Vulnerabilities in audited systems, until fixed
Aggregate audit results, by lab	Training data and logs supplied by labs

What is sealed does not stay in the dark. An external oversight commission, with clearance and no seat at any lab, sees everything and publishes annually *what* it verified without publishing *how*. Transparency of process, secrecy of method — the same model democracies use to oversee their intelligence services.

And every secret has an expiry. A detector that has already been bypassed, or already has a successor, is published. The catalog grows toward the open side, never the other way.

Who watches the watcher

We do not ask for trust. We ask you to verify these structures.

Seat. An international foundation in a neutral jurisdiction, protected by treaty against unilateral requisition by any state.

Capital. A founding endowment, split between frontier labs and a consortium of governments, deposited once. No bloc holds a majority. No deposit can be withdrawn.

Board. Eleven seats in three benches: four appointed by guarantor governments, four scientists elected by peers, three from civil society. Zero voting seats for labs. Grave decisions require a majority in each bench separately — none of them governs alone.

Directorship. A fixed six-year term, non-renewable. A five-year quarantine before any tie to an audited lab, for the director and for all senior technical staff.

Oversight. An external commission with full access and security clearance; annual public financial audit; a protected whistleblower channel for staff.

Our own model. Runs in a sandbox, with minimal permissions, monitored by a previous-generation system, with humans able to switch it off at any moment. No action of its own takes effect without a human signature. The rule we apply to others is the first we apply to ourselves.

Death clause

An institution that cannot die becomes a perpetual power. An institution whose death leaves an inheritance becomes a target. We designed ours so that neither happens.

Who can dissolve us. Only a qualified majority in each of the board's three benches, voting separately, after a year of public consultation. No government, group of governments or donor can do it alone.

What happens to what we know. The police model and the sealed detectors are destroyed, not transferred. So that "destroyed" is not a promise, it is cryptography: weights and sensitive catalog are encrypted under a key split among custodians with no common interest — governments, scientists, civil society and an independent legal custodian. No bloc alone reconstitutes anything. If Nescience dies, the secret dies with it.

What happens to the money. The endowment goes to a successor entity with this same charter or, in its absence, to open research in AI safety. Never to states. Never to labs.

The only way to use what Nescience knows is to keep it alive and working as it was designed.

The citizen fund

An institution funded only by those it audits and those it constrains will never be entirely anyone else's. So the endowment has a third source: ordinary people and entities, from any country.

How it works. Donations from individuals, foundations, universities, companies outside the AI frontier, cities and civil-society organizations enter the same irrevocable endowment — same rules, same protection. A donor may give once or monthly; in local currency, by transfer or by cryptocurrency; anonymously if they wish. What they cannot do is buy influence.

Cap per donor. No person or entity may account for more than 1% of the total endowment. Above that, the donation is declined or redirected to open research. The cap exists so that the citizen fund belongs to many, never to one billionaire.

What the donor receives. No vote, no seat, no access. They receive what everyone receives: public audited accounts, annual oversight reports, and the right to verify that the money went where we said.

The civil-society bench. The three board seats reserved for civil society are elected by the citizen fund's donors — one person, one vote, regardless of the amount given. It is the only form of influence money buys here, and it is equal for whoever gave ten or ten thousand.

Goal. That the citizen fund reach one third of the endowment within ten years. The day that happens, no government and no lab will be able to call Nescience theirs.

Invitation

To the labs: you have the capital, the access and, in your own words, the conviction that this is necessary. Fund it once, grant access by contract and accept being audited by those who have nothing to sell. It is the only arrangement in which the public's trust does not depend on your word.

To governments: none of you trusts the others, and rightly so. This is the institution none of you controls — and therefore the only one all of you can accept. Sign the treaty before the incident, not after.

To researchers: interpretability is years behind the capability curve. Control is the insurance until it arrives. Come build the insurance.

To citizens: do not believe us. Verify. Everything we claim about ourselves is written to be tested — and if one day it stops being true, this manifesto is the proof that we failed.

Minds we do not understand already work among us. The question is not whether someone will watch them. It is whether the watcher will be watched too.

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